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February 2, 2026

Thomas Lee's nomination to the Distinguished Teaching Award

Dear Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award Selection Committee,

I am very pleased to write this letter in strong support of Mr. Thomas Lee's nomination for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. As his PhD advisor in the Mechanical and Aerospace Engineering Department, I have had the opportunity to observe Thomas's development as both a researcher and an educator, and I can state without reservation that he is among the most effective and dedicated Teaching Assistants with whom I have worked at UCLA.

I have personally recommended Thomas to serve as a Teaching Assistant for introductory Thermodynamics over multiple academic years because of his exceptional command of the material, his reliability, and—most importantly—his thoughtful, student-centered approach to teaching. Thermodynamics is a foundational and challenging course required for mechanical, aerospace, and civil engineering students, and assigning the right TA is critical. Thomas consistently demonstrates the judgment, preparation, and pedagogical skill necessary to support students in mastering this difficult material.

What distinguishes Thomas as a TA is his ability to guide students toward genuine understanding rather than surface-level problem solving. He emphasizes structured reasoning, physical intuition, and clear justification of assumptions, helping students develop analytical habits that extend well beyond a single course. His discussion sections are highly interactive, carefully paced, and deliberately designed to engage students in the process of problem-solving rather than passive note-taking. This approach aligns closely with current best practices in engineering education and has proven effective across many quarters of instruction.

In addition to his direct impact on students, Thomas has played an important informal leadership role among Teaching Assistants. Having taught this course repeatedly, he has shared effective strategies with other TAs, contributing to consistency and quality across discussion sections. These joint instructional efforts have translated into measurable outcomes: departmental ABET assessment metrics consistently indicate that 80% or more of students demonstrate a solid understanding of thermodynamic analysis, reflecting the effectiveness of the teaching practices Thomas helps model and reinforce.

Beyond his teaching ability, Thomas is professional, dependable, and deeply committed to student success. He takes his instructional responsibilities seriously and approaches teaching with the same rigor and integrity that he brings to his research. It is precisely this combination of intellectual strength, pedagogical skill, and reliability that has led me to repeatedly entrust him with this critical instructional role.

I give Thomas Lee my highest recommendation for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. He exemplifies the values this award is meant to recognize, and I am confident that his contributions have had a lasting and positive impact on our students and our department.

Sincerely,



Laurent Pilon

Over the course of eleven academic quarters as a Teaching Assistant at UCLA, I have developed a student-centered approach to teaching that aligns strongly with the goals of the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. My experience includes nine quarters as a TA for Introductory Thermodynamics in the Mechanical Engineering department and two quarters with the UCLA CEED Program, where I taught Math 31B (equivalent to AP Calculus BC) to incoming first-year engineering students. Across these roles, my core goal has been to make challenging technical material accessible, engaging, and understandable for students with diverse academic backgrounds.

One of the most important aspects of my teaching are discussions. Rather than treating discussion sections as mini-lectures, I design them around guided problem-solving, frequent check-ins, and Socratic questioning. In Thermodynamics, a course that many students find abstract and intimidating, I emphasize engineering thought processes over memorization, asking students why a particular approach is appropriate before moving into equations. Student feedback repeatedly highlights this strength, noting that discussions helped them "think about the process of solving the problem" and that working through problems together "cemented [their] understanding." My consistent use of participation-centric discussions has helped students in not only becoming more confident in exams and homework, but being equipped to be problem-solving engineers.

The secret to these discussions is preparation and clarity. For each discussion section, I highlighted notes that summarize key lecture concepts, identify common misconceptions, and scaffold example problems from basic intuition to full solutions. Multiple students have commented on how helpful these notes and examples were, particularly in bridging the gap between lecture theory and applied problem-solving. This approach has contributed to consistently strong teaching evaluations, with overall ratings ranging from 7.44 to 8.33 out of 9 across multiple quarters, even as course formats and student cohorts changed.

Additionally, inclusive teaching is central to my practice. I strive to create an environment where students feel comfortable asking questions, making mistakes, and participating regardless of prior preparation. I do my best to learn student names, invite multiple solution strategies, and normalize partial or incorrect attempts as part of learning so that each student in the class is seen and knows that they belong and can succeed in this class. Student comments noting that I was "very welcoming to questions," "approachable," and that knowing their names showed I "cared about teaching" affirm the effectiveness of this approach. In CEED, where students are transitioning into the rigor of UCLA coursework, this inclusivity was especially critical. I focused on building confidence alongside content mastery, helping students see themselves as capable engineers and mathematicians.

Over multiple quarters of teaching thermodynamics, I regularly worked with new and returning TAs to share effective discussion strategies, problem-solving frameworks, and approaches to

student engagement. I would share how to structure sections around guided questioning rather than solution delivery, how to pace problems to maintain momentum, and how to encourage participation from students with varied confidence levels. From these joint efforts, this required class for mechanical, aerospace, and civil engineers consistently produces students who have solid understanding of thermodynamic analyses, with ABET-reported metrics showing that 80% or more of students meet or exceed expected learning outcomes. I view this informal TA training as an extension of my teaching practice supporting undergraduate students and also developing my peers as thoughtful educators.

Finally, I view teaching as an iterative practice. Over multiple offerings of the same course, I have refined pacing, participation strategies, and examples based on student feedback and self-reflection. One student observed that it was “clear he’s found a groove,” which I view not as routine but as evidence of continuous improvement grounded in experience and responsiveness.

Taken together, my teaching record demonstrates a sustained pattern of effective, inclusive, and student-centered instruction. I aim not only to help students succeed in a difficult course, but to leave them with confidence in their ability to reason through complex engineering problems. I believe this commitment strongly reflects the spirit and criteria of the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

As I remembered my own experiences as an undergraduate student, the TAs and their approach to student learning was the difference between an easy course at UCLA or a difficult one. I knew that I could be someone who either inspires the next generations of engineers to love thermodynamics or be so frustrated that they learn the material spitefully, in fear of the next quiz or exam that will reinforce their disinterest in the subject. My teaching philosophy is grounded in the belief that learning occurs most effectively when students are actively engaged, intellectually challenged, and supported in an inclusive environment that values personal curiosity and wonder over perfection. As a Teaching Assistant in Mechanical Engineering and in the UCLA Center for Excellence in Engineering and Diversity Program, I see my role not as a transmitter of solutions, but as a guide who helps students develop the habits of thinking that define successful engineers.

Engineering courses, particularly introductory Thermodynamics, often overwhelm students with equations, charts, and abstract concepts. One of the most difficult challenges of this class is that many students have never seen a turbine or heat exchanger so they are unable to visualize what is physically occurring when we introduce these complex equations. My central instructional goal is to demystify this complexity by emphasizing structured problem-solving. Rather than solving problems for students, I solve problems with them, and I frequently pause to ask what information is relevant, what assumptions apply, or what a reasonable answer should look like. This transforms discussion sections into collaborative learning spaces rather than passive review sessions where I just write down what the solution manual says. Students have noted that this approach helped them “think about the process” and retain material more effectively than lecture alone. I have made it so that attending discussions is going to help them build a sense of how an engineer applies their theories into analysis and that it is much better to make mistakes now so that these errors will not be repeated in an exam or in their future workplaces. This guided approach to engineering problem solving with immediate, personalized feedback for each student encourages deeper understanding and helps students adopt a framework they can apply independently.

Not every student is comfortable speaking aloud to the rest of the discussion section, but I have found strategies to still make these students be seen and part of the classroom dynamics. By designing my discussion sections around think-aloud problem solving, there were rarely any moments of silence, and I could see that even students in the back of the class were engaging in peer-to-peer conversations, allowing me to move from taking answers from the front of the room to the back. In these time-limited sections, I prioritize engagement over coverage, trusting that students learn more from grappling with fewer problems deeply than from watching many solved quickly. I vary who I call on, encourage multiple solution paths, and validate partial progress to ensure that participation does not become intimidating. In the moments where students hesitate to give any answer and silence fills the air, I ask different questions that may not be in the immediate scope of the problem but would build up their intuition or next steps rather than final answers. Everyone gets stuck sometimes, and by bringing this reality to the forefront of the

discussion, students with different confidence levels and backgrounds are able to contribute meaningfully.

It is important to note that the most effective teaching methods must align with how students are assessed. As someone who is also given the responsibility for grading, I regularly connect discussion material to homework, quizzes, and exams, explicitly highlighting common pitfalls that students will make and emphasizing effective strategies that save time. When grading, I do not make my rubrics ambiguous, but leave specific comments whenever possible so that when they receive their results, they have clear points of improvements to work on. In office hours or discussions after assessments, students are given the opportunity to bring up anything they do not understand, whereupon I guide them through reflection on mistakes and misconceptions, helping them see errors as diagnostic tools rather than failures. My goal is to help students become self-regulated learners who can evaluate and improve their own problem-solving approaches.

My experience with the UCLA CEED Program reinforced the importance of this approach. Teaching Math 31B to incoming freshmen, many of whom were adjusting to UCLA's pace and expectations, required intentional encouragement and clarity. I focused not only on mathematical techniques, but also on helping students develop confidence in their ability to succeed in a rigorous academic environment. Obstacles will come, and some instructors may just expect you to "know it," but I wanted them to come out of this class with a mindset that faces challenges with curiosity rather than exhaustion. Inclusivity in teaching means recognizing that students arrive with different levels of preparation, confidence, and external pressures. I strive to create a classroom culture where asking questions is normalized and mistakes are treated as opportunities for learning. Simple practices such as learning student names, checking in verbally, and responding respectfully to confusion go a long way in building trust.

I view teaching as an evolving practice. Having taught the same course across multiple quarters, I continuously refine my methods based on student feedback and outcomes. I adjust pacing, participation strategies, and examples to better serve each cohort while maintaining clear learning objectives.

Looking ahead, my goal is to carry these values of clarity, inclusivity, and active engagement into future instructional roles. Being someone who is given the opportunity to be in higher education and teach, my aim is to help students not only master technical content, but also develop confidence, curiosity, and resilience as learners. My role as a teacher is to best equip students with ways of thinking that extend far beyond a single course, and that is the standard I strive to uphold.

S23 - 7.87/9 (n=31)

- I loved discussions. I learn more during discussion than in class. I think this was a heavy application based class and I loved actually apply what we did in class during discussion it made doing the homework a lot easier.
- My TA was beyond helpful and I enjoyed going to every discussion section as I felt it helped me learn the content to perform well on the homework and exams
- Thomas explains things very well and is always happy to help me out. I appreciate his energy in the classroom!
- Thomas was very helpful in teaching the different concepts we learned throughout the quarter. His examples were explained thoroughly and his notes were very easy to follow. He is very approachable and is always available to answer any questions that students may have. He has helped me learn how to use different equations in a way that lectures were not able to do. Without Thomas I would be struggling way more than I am now

W24 - 8.13/9 (n=15)

- I really enjoyed the discussion sections run by Thomas. He was very good at going over the discussion problems in a way that he was not just doing the answers but engaging the class and trying to get the class to think about the process of solving the problem.
- Lee was an amazing TA. His discussions were extremely helpful and he was very supportive of the other student. Lee encouraged students to participate in discussions and worked through problems at a good pace by explaining approaches and concepts. Thumbs up all around.

S24 - 8.23/9 (n=13)

- My TA was super knowledgable, prepared, and was good at explaining the material. I think he was very welcoming to questions and even knew a lot of our names which shows he cared about teaching. It definitely helped me with the course material. I can't think of any weaknesses.
- This TA was great! He summarized lecture material well, did helpful practice problems and was always willing and able to answer additional questions. I really appreciated discussion sections as they helped my learning in this course!

F24 - 8.29 (n=21)

- Thomas did a great job of leading the discussions and making the sessions engaging. It really helped to go through examples to demonstrate how to apply the topics that we learned in class.
- Thomas was one of my favorite TAs. He was very knowledgeable about the content and does a great job at explaining the thought process behind why you use certain methods. He is also very approachable.

W25 - 7.87/9 (n=15)

- Thomas has been teaching this course for a while and it's clear he's found a groove. He's relatable, communicative, and helps his students succeed. His teaching style is

almost Socratic, as he insists on class participation to solve problems. I spent a lot of time answering his questions, and it helped cement my understanding, but I'm not sure if that was a universally appreciated strategy. I'm very grateful that he wouldn't run all the way up until the end, especially since it was a Friday afternoon discussion. I felt like he overall was a better TA than SoYoung compared to when I would attend her discussions, and I typically walked out of his discussions sooner and with a better understanding of what was happening. I'm glad we did problems together instead of just doing them independently in the same room - if I wanted that approach, I'd just do the discussion problems at home and then check the key.

- Thomas was an amazing teaching assistant for this course because the content he provided during discussions was very clear. He always tries to provide a little recap of what we learned before we start example problems, which is great as a refresher after the week of lecture content. He is also great at encouraging students to engage in solving example problems and thoroughly explains all the steps we need to remember while still managing to always get through everything in a very timely manner. Additionally, he has energy during the entire time that keeps the momentum of the discussion going and in my personal experience, it really helps maintain my focus. I don't believe I can think of any weaknesses I can point out

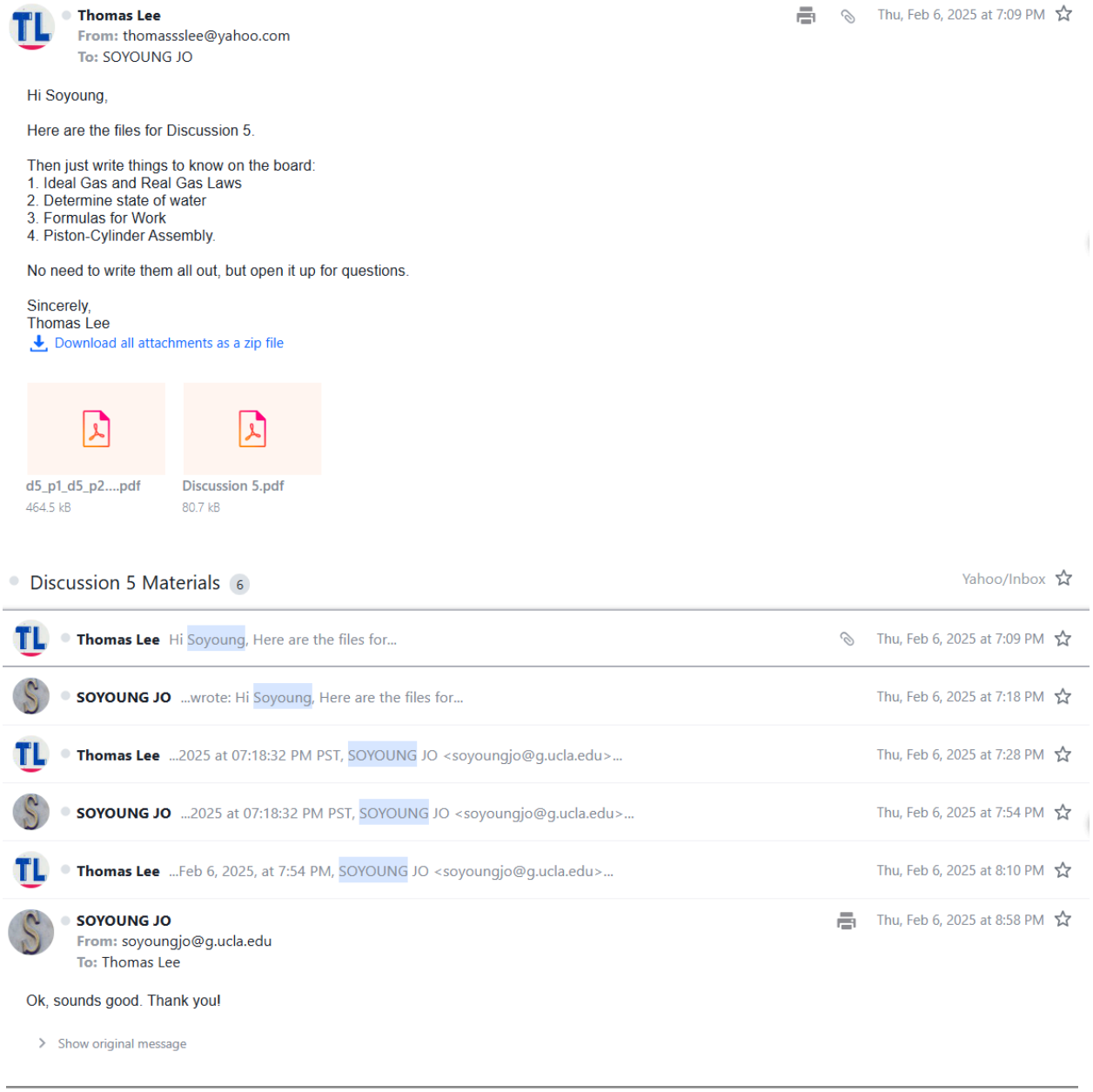
S25 - 8.33/9 (n=15)

- Thomas is perfect. He is my favorite TA I have ever had and a god sent. He always knew how to answer our questions and really helped us understand how to approach problems as he would ask us to solve it step by step and about how we would approach them. He would also walk us through the solutions to quizzes and exams so we knew where we went wrong and what mistakes we made. I felt very comfortable being able to ask questions about exams, homework, and general content.
- Thomas is the GOAT! He explains concepts clearly and thoroughly and is very approachable. This is a tough class with a lot of reading charts and plug and chug formulas but if you have Thomas as your TA you will at least learn something. Honestly I'm not sure how I'm going to do in the course because I've been slacking but trust me Thomas is a good TA to have
- The teaching assistant, Thomas, organized the discussions to complement the course very well. I felt that we reviewed all of the important concepts and did practice problems that adequately prepared me for examinations. He explained concepts very succinctly and was always able to answer questions, so I felt that he was an excellent teaching assistant.

F25 - 7.44/9 (n=25)

- The TA had very well prepared discussion notes and problems. He was very helpful when asked about course material and homework questions.
- The TA is very knowledgeable and explains problem solving steps well. Answers questions students may have and clarifies any conceptual confusion during discussion. Communication is very clear.

Trained and collaborated with my co-TA Soyoung Jo for Academic Year 2024-2025. Our typical email correspondence would look similar to this, with me sending out the material for discussion and emphasizing certain points that we should both cover to clear up any confusion in the class.



Thomas Lee
From: thomassslee@yahoo.com
To: SOYOUNG JO

Thu, Feb 6, 2025 at 7:09 PM

Hi Soyoung,

Here are the files for Discussion 5.

Then just write things to know on the board:
1. Ideal Gas and Real Gas Laws
2. Determine state of water
3. Formulas for Work
4. Piston-Cylinder Assembly.

No need to write them all out, but open it up for questions.

Sincerely,
Thomas Lee
Download all attachments as a zip file

d5_p1_d5_p2....pdf
464.5 kB

Discussion 5.pdf
80.7 kB

Discussion 5 Materials 6 — Yahoo/Inbox

Thomas Lee Hi Soyoung, Here are the files for... — Thu, Feb 6, 2025 at 7:09 PM

SOYOUNG JO ...wrote: Hi Soyoung, Here are the files for... — Thu, Feb 6, 2025 at 7:18 PM

Thomas Lee ...2025 at 07:18:32 PM PST, SOYOUNG JO <soyoungjo@g.ucla.edu>... — Thu, Feb 6, 2025 at 7:28 PM

SOYOUNG JO ...2025 at 07:18:32 PM PST, SOYOUNG JO <soyoungjo@g.ucla.edu>... — Thu, Feb 6, 2025 at 7:54 PM

Thomas Lee ...Feb 6, 2025, at 7:54 PM, SOYOUNG JO <soyoungjo@g.ucla.edu>... — Thu, Feb 6, 2025 at 8:10 PM

SOYOUNG JO
From: soyoungjo@g.ucla.edu
To: Thomas Lee

Thu, Feb 6, 2025 at 8:58 PM

Ok, sounds good. Thank you!

Show original message

Also trained and collaborated with my co-TA Min Jong Kil for Fall 2025. This was his first time TA-ing and seeing the material so they are a bit more detailed than my correspondence with Soyoung.

Thomas Lee
From: thomassslee@yahoo.com
To: MIN JONG KIL

Wed, Oct 8, 2025 at 3:56 PM

Hi Min Jong,

Here are the discussion questions for this week; other things to include are:

P = P_abs = P_atm + P_gage; P that is given in the problems are assumed absolute pressure unless stated that it is gage pressure.

Go over how to determine state briefly.
Given (P,T) -> Look at T_sat(P). If T < T_sat, compressed liq, T > T_sat superheated vap.
Given (P, v) or (T, v) -> Look at v_f and v_g at the given property. Then compare v to v_f and/or v_g to determine state.

In an ideal gas problem, if state 1 is an ideal gas and it goes to a new pressure, temperature, does that mean state 2 is also an ideal gas? How do you check? Then open the room for questions in how to determine z.

Lastly, how a piston moves if it hits a stopper (const P, changing volume vs const V, changing pressure)

Let me know if you have questions,
Thomas

Download all attachments as a zip file

F25_Discussi....pdf
369.9 kB

F25_Discussi....pdf
105.2 kB

MIN JONG KIL
From: hjkz3514@g.ucla.edu
To: Thomas Lee

Fri, Oct 10, 2025 at 1:05 AM

Hi Thomas,

Thanks for letting me know.

Could you make a comment during discussion 4-6 PM that v with an upper bar is volume divided by mol not molecular weight? I think I said volume divided by molecular weight last week. Thanks.

Best,
Min Jong

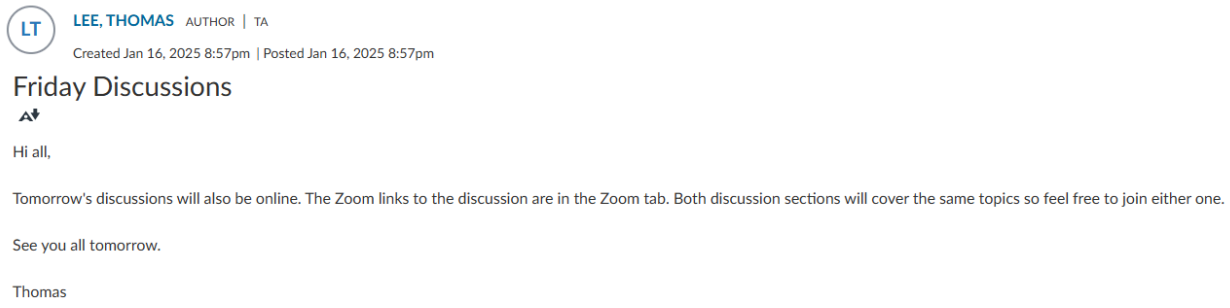
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Min Jong Kil
Ph.D. candidate
Department of Mechanical and Aerospace Engineering, UCLA
Nano Transport Research Group (NTRG)
420 Westwood Plaza (Engineering IV), Rm: 47-112, Los Angeles, CA 90095, US
Mobile: +1-424-440-9668
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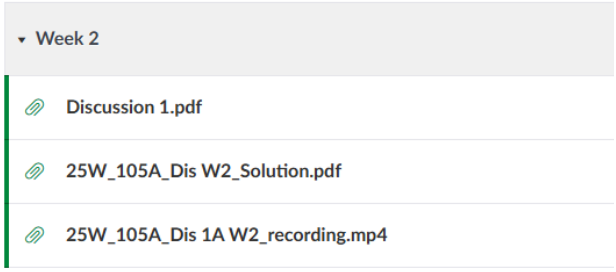
One unique experience of being TA was leading discussions during the LA wildfires and helping Prof. Amar have recorded online lectures. First we wanted to clearly inform students that their safety should come first:



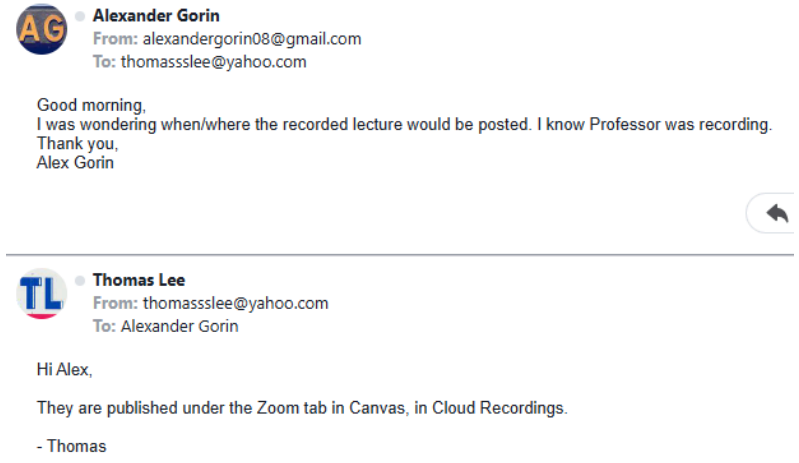
Then to accommodate student safety and any sudden changes in schedule, we quickly set up online discussions via Zoom, where we could still interact with any student that had a need.



The discussion recording was then uploaded to Bruinlearn, readily available for students to view.



At the same time, lectures were recorded on Zoom and were available to be viewed on the Zoom cloud recordings.



Alexander Gorin
From: alexandergorin08@gmail.com
To: thomassslee@yahoo.com

Good morning,
I was wondering when/where the recorded lecture would be posted. I know Professor was recording.
Thank you,
Alex Gorin

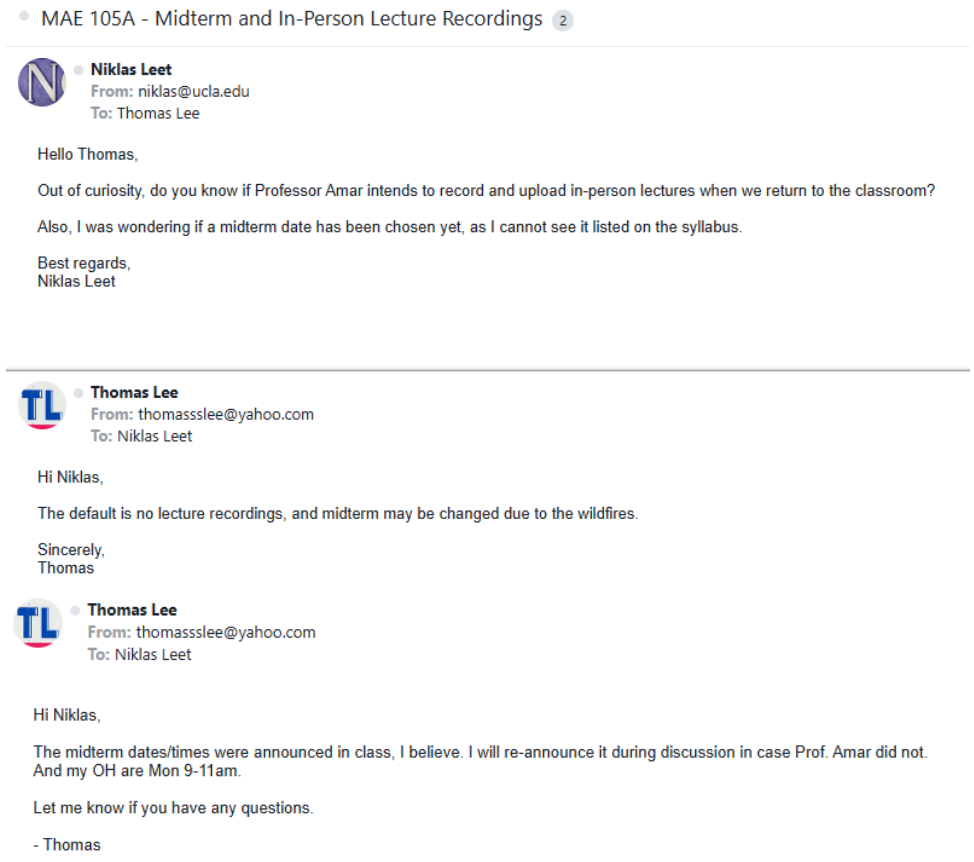
Thomas Lee
From: thomassslee@yahoo.com
To: Alexander Gorin

Hi Alex,

They are published under the Zoom tab in Canvas, in Cloud Recordings.

- Thomas

We also had to transition back into “regular” lecture schedules, and that was communicated to students as well. However, due to the wildfires, we needed to adapt to a new examination schedule too.



MAE 105A - Midterm and In-Person Lecture Recordings 2

Niklas Leet
From: niklas@ucla.edu
To: Thomas Lee

Hello Thomas,

Out of curiosity, do you know if Professor Amar intends to record and upload in-person lectures when we return to the classroom?

Also, I was wondering if a midterm date has been chosen yet, as I cannot see it listed on the syllabus.

Best regards,
Niklas Leet

Thomas Lee
From: thomassslee@yahoo.com
To: Niklas Leet

Hi Niklas,

The default is no lecture recordings, and midterm may be changed due to the wildfires.

Sincerely,
Thomas

Thomas Lee
From: thomassslee@yahoo.com
To: Niklas Leet

Hi Niklas,

The midterm dates/times were announced in class, I believe. I will re-announce it during discussion in case Prof. Amar did not. And my OH are Mon 9-11am.

Let me know if you have any questions.

- Thomas

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

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UCLA Engineering
HENRY SAMUELI SCHOOL OF ENGINEERING AND APPLIED SCIENCE
Mechanical and Aerospace Engineering Department
Ravnesh Amar
Ravnesh.amar@gmail.com
420 Westwood Plaza, Eng. IV, Room 37-132
Los Angeles, CA 90095-1597

February 4, 2026

Thomas Lee's nomination for the Distinguished Teaching Award

Dear Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award Selection Committee,

I am delighted to recommend **Thomas Lee** for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award based on his outstanding performance as a Teaching Assistant in my introductory Thermodynamics course (MAE105A). Thomas has been the TA for this class eight times since 2023. During this time, I have seen firsthand the exceptional quality, consistency, and care that Thomas brings to his teaching.

Introductory Thermodynamics is one of the most demanding core courses in our curriculum, enrolling students from mechanical, aerospace, and civil engineering disciplines. Many students struggle not because of a lack of effort, but because they have difficulty translating basic principles into structured analysis. Thomas excels precisely at bridging this gap. Based on feedback from the students, his discussion sections are well-organized, engaging, and intentionally designed to help students understand *how* to think through problems rather than simply arrive at numerical answers.

Thomas's teaching style is highly interactive. He actively involves students in problem-solving, asks targeted questions to promote understanding, and encourages students to articulate their reasoning step by step. This approach fosters a classroom environment where students feel comfortable participating, asking questions, and learning from mistakes. Student feedback consistently reflects this impact, with many describing his discussions as essential to their understanding of the course material.

What I particularly value about Thomas as a TA is his preparation and alignment with course goals. His discussion materials complement lecture content effectively, reinforce key concepts, and directly support student performance on homework and exams. He is also highly responsive to student needs, adjusting pacing and explanations based on real-time feedback from the class. As an instructor, I have complete confidence in his ability to represent the course accurately and thoughtfully.

Thomas has also contributed positively to the broader instructional team. He collaborates well with other TAs, and is a good mentor by sharing effective teaching practices, and helps maintain a high standard across discussion sections. These collective efforts have supported strong learning outcomes, as reflected in departmental assessment results showing that a large majority of students meet or exceed expected learning objectives in thermodynamic analysis.

In short, Thomas Lee is an exceptional Teaching Assistant whose impact extends well beyond his assigned discussion sections. His commitment to inclusive, student-centered teaching and his sustained excellence over many quarters make him an ideal candidate for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.
I recommend him enthusiastically and without reservation.

Sincerely,
Ravnesh Amar